Language Testing in Asia

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Assessment for learning or assessment for scoring? Washback of analytic rubrics in Vietnamese EFL classrooms

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Abstract

This study investigates the washback effects of EFL lecturers' use of analytic rubrics for assessing students' writing performance in Vietnamese higher education. Although analytic rubrics are widely promoted for enhancing assessment transparency and supporting student learning, little is known about how lecturers implement them in practice and how their use influences teaching and learning behaviors. Drawing on Washback Theory and Assessment for Learning principles, this qualitative study involved semi-structured interviews with nine Vietnamese EFL lecturers across two institutions, representing novice, mid-career, and near-end-career stages. Thematic analysis revealed considerable variation in rubric implementation: novice lecturers tended to use rubrics rigidly for scoring, while more experienced lecturers integrated rubrics into instructional processes to support student learning. Lecturers' perceptions of rubrics evolved over time, with greater teaching experience leading to a more formative and reflective use, although institutional constraints sometimes limited their flexibility. Rubric use often helped clarify writing expectations and supported student self-monitoring, but it sometimes led to formulaic writing when not well integrated into instruction. These findings highlight the dynamic, context-dependent nature of rubric washback and underscore the need for sustained professional development, culturally responsive rubric design, and institutional support to promote the effective use of assessment tools in EFL writing classrooms.

Keywords: Analytic rubrics, Assessment for learning, Assessment for scoring, Vietnamese EFL classrooms, Washback

Introduction

In recent decades, writing assessment has evolved from impressionistic scoring toward more structured and transparent methods, with analytic rubrics becoming increasingly central in evaluating student writing performance. Analytic rubrics, by breaking down writing into discrete components such as content, organization, vocabulary, language use, and mechanics, aim to offer more consistent and detailed feedback to learners and more reliable data for educators and institutions (Barkaoui, 2010; Moskal, 2000). Within the field of English as a Foreign Language (EFL) education, the adoption of analytic rubrics not only seeks to promote fairer and more objective evaluations but also serves

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as a tool to guide instruction, develop learner autonomy, and enhance writing pedagogy (Andrade, 2005).

One critical but underexplored consequence of implementing assessment tools like analytic rubrics is washback—the influence of testing and assessment practices on teaching and learning (Alderson & Wall, 1993). Washback can be positive, steering teaching and learning toward desired outcomes, or negative, leading to superficial engagement or narrowing of instruction (Green, 2007a, 2007b). In the EFL context, lecturers' use of analytic rubrics may shape classroom practices, curriculum design, feedback strategies, and students' perceptions of writing itself. However, while studies have investigated the washback effects of large-scale language tests (e.g., TOEFL, IELTS), little empirical attention has been devoted to examining how localized assessment tools, such as instructor-developed analytic rubrics, impact everyday teaching and learning dynamics in tertiary EFL classrooms.

Furthermore, how lecturers interpret, adapt, and operationalize analytic rubrics in their assessment practices remains an open question. While rubrics are often intended to standardize and clarify evaluation, their use is mediated by lecturers' beliefs, experiences, and contextual realities, potentially leading to varied forms of washback (Fleming & Chambers, 1983). Recognizing these challenges is important for improving rubric design and guiding professional development to make rubric-based assessment more effective.

Literature review

Washback in language assessment

The concept of washback—the influence of testing on teaching and learning—has been a major concern in language assessment research for over three decades. Alderson and Wall's (1993) early work argued that tests do not have the same effect in every context, introducing a set of "washback hypotheses" to explain how test impact varies across settings. Subsequent scholars, such as Green (2007a, 2007b) and Shih (2007), further refined the definition, emphasizing that washback can be positive or negative depending on whether it promotes meaningful learning or encourages superficial test-driven behaviors. In the context of writing instruction, assessment washback can manifest in how teachers structure tasks, the types of feedback they provide, and the skills they prioritize. Positive washback occurs when assessment practices lead to the development of higher-order writing abilities and critical thinking, while negative washback may result when teachers "teach to the rubric" in a rigid and formulaic manner, thereby limiting learners' writing development (Shih, 2009).

More recent literature has expanded the scope of washback to explore how formative assessment practices mediate its effects. Researchers such as Carless and Winstone (2019) argued that sustainable feedback and formative assessment are key to generating long-term positive washback. When analytic rubrics are used formatively, not just to assign grades but to guide reflection, peer assessment, and self-regulation, they can activate productive learning behaviors and help students internalize quality criteria (English et al., 2022; Panadero et al., 2018). Thus, washback should not be viewed as a unidirectional outcome of assessment design but as an interactional and recursive process that reflects how students and teachers use feedback tools in real-time learning contexts.

An important but underexplored dimension of this process is teacher experience. While many studies focus on assessment tools, newer research shows that teachers' assessment practices are strongly influenced by their teaching experience. Fulmer et al. (2015) highlighted that teachers' assessment practices evolve with their experience, as more seasoned teachers tend to develop more flexible, reflective, and pedagogically integrated uses of assessment tools. In contrast, novice teachers often implement assessment more rigidly due to limited confidence or institutional pressures. These findings suggest that teacher experience plays a mediating role in washback, influencing whether rubrics serve formative purposes or reinforce mechanical compliance.

Analytic rubrics in writing assessment

Analytic rubrics are scoring tools that divide writing into specific categories, with separate scores assigned to each component (e.g., content, organization, vocabulary, grammar, mechanics). Compared to holistic rubrics, which provide a single overall score, analytic rubrics offer more detailed feedback, making them especially valuable for formative assessment and instructional purposes (Jonsson & Svingby, 2007). In EFL contexts, analytic rubrics help learners better understand the multifaceted nature of good writing and can scaffold self-assessment and revision processes (Andrade, 2005). However, scholars have also cautioned that the effectiveness of rubrics depends on how they are implemented. Panadero and Jonsson (2013) stressed that rubrics must be integrated thoughtfully into instruction rather than treated merely as scoring instruments. Without proper training or understanding, teachers might use rubrics inconsistently or focus narrowly on checklist-like criteria, which can produce counterproductive washback effects.

Recent studies have emphasized that the pedagogical value of analytic rubrics lies in their potential to clarify learning goals and enable formative feedback loops. For example, Joseph et al. (2020) highlighted how rubrics can support dialogic assessment practices when lecturers and students co-construct or interpret criteria together. This kind of collaboration helps students go beyond simply following the rubrics and start understanding what good writing looks like in their field (Panadero et al., 2017). Furthermore, formative rubric use is especially important in higher education, where students are expected to develop independent writing strategies. If lecturers merely apply rubrics summatively without involving students in the assessment process, rubrics risk functioning as static accountability tools rather than learning resources.

Washback effects of rubric use

Despite the recognized potential of analytic rubrics to enhance learning, research into their washback effects remains relatively limited, especially within EFL higher education contexts. Some studies suggest that rubrics can serve as catalysts for pedagogical change, encouraging more transparent communication between instructors and students (Andrade et al., 2008). Others indicate that unless lecturers critically engage with rubrics, the intended positive washback may not materialize (Fraile et al., 2017). Key factors influencing rubric washback include lecturers' assessment literacy, institutional expectations, and students' familiarity with rubric-based evaluation systems. Furthermore, cultural expectations about assessment (e.g., attitudes toward explicitness in

evaluation criteria) may mediate how rubrics are perceived and used in different educational contexts (Cheng et al., 2004).

In addition, the degree of teaching experience appears to shape not only how rubrics are used but also the extent to which they are integrated into instructional design. More experienced lecturers may be better equipped to balance institutional demands with pedagogical objectives, using rubrics as tools for formative dialogue rather than merely evaluative checklists (Fulmer et al., 2015; Klenowski, 2011). This suggests that understanding washback requires attention not only to assessment tools but also to the evolving assessment beliefs and repertoires of individual educators.

Recent studies have shown more clearly how using rubrics in teaching can influence both instructional practices and student learning. For example, Andrade et al. (2008) found that when lecturers discussed rubrics with students during the drafting phase, learners were better able to use them to plan and revise their work, indicating strong formative washback. Similarly, Xu and Brown (2016) argue that formative assessment practices using rubrics promote student agency and assessment literacy, both of which are central to positive washback. These findings align closely with Assessment for Learning principles, reinforcing the notion that rubrics must be embedded in classroom dialogue and feedback practices to exert meaningful instructional influence. Without such integration, rubrics may reinforce surface-level engagement or procedural compliance rather than genuine writing development.

Related studies

Several empirical studies have explored the use of analytic rubrics in language teaching and their associated washback effects, revealing both potential benefits and challenges. Cheng and Warren (2005) studied how detailed analytic rubrics were used in a Hong Kong English for Academic Purposes (EAP) course. They found that the rubrics helped students better understand academic writing standards and improved their overall writing, though some students felt overwhelmed by the number of criteria. Similarly, Andrade et al. (2008) demonstrated in a quasi-experimental study with American middle and high school students that explicit instruction in rubric use significantly enhanced writing outcomes, emphasizing the need to teach rubric interpretation skills to fully realize positive washback.

Extending these insights into higher education contexts, Fraile et al. (2017) found that while Spanish university lecturers valued rubrics for providing clarity and consistency, informal adaptations often undermined their intended transparency, resulting in mixed washback effects. Addressing rubric use in standardized assessment settings, Hamp-Lyons (2007) cautioned that even carefully designed rubrics could unintentionally promote formulaic writing behaviors, thus influencing both student production and teachers' instructional strategies. Similarly, Saito (2008), in a study of Japanese university writing classes, found that lecturers' beliefs about writing influenced whether rubrics were used to support meaningful learning or just to reinforce a focus on grammar. Collectively, these studies suggest that while analytic rubrics can improve writing performance and more transparent assessment, their effectiveness largely depends on how they are implemented, interpreted, and integrated into instructional practices.

Despite a growing body of research on the technical and pedagogical merits of analytic rubrics, their localized washback effects in everyday classroom contexts remain underexplored—particularly in EFL settings such as Vietnamese higher education. Previous studies have largely focused on rubric use in standardized assessments or on student outcomes, with less attention given to how lecturers' assessment behaviors and instructional strategies are shaped by rubric use over time. Moreover, the literature has not sufficiently addressed how lecturers' professional experience mediates rubric implementation, nor how analytic rubrics function as tools for either formative learning or rigid compliance. These omissions limit our understanding of how rubrics operate not only as evaluative instruments but as pedagogical agents in context-specific teaching ecologies.

To address these gaps, this study examines the washback effects of EFL lecturers' use of analytic rubrics on their writing instruction and assessment practices. In line with Washback Theory (WT), the study explores how the use of analytic rubrics influences teaching behaviors, instructional decisions, and student engagement with writing tasks in Vietnamese higher education. The study is guided by the following research question: *What are the washback effects of analytic rubric use on EFL lecturers' assessment practices, instructional approaches, and students' writing development?* By examining these issues, the study adds to existing research on assessment washback and suggests ways to improve writing assessment in EFL settings.

Methods

Research design

This study adopts a qualitative research design to explore the washback effects of EFL lecturers' use of analytic rubrics on their assessment practices, instructional approaches, and students' writing development. Qualitative research is well suited to exploring how washback works in different settings, helping to show how lecturers understand, use, and respond to rubric-based assessment in their teaching (Dörnyei, 2007). Rather than aiming to produce generalizable results, this study focuses on describing the specific practices and views related to rubric use within one educational context.

The study is theoretically grounded in two major frameworks: Washback Theory (WT) (Alderson & Wall, 1993; Green, 2007a, 2007b) and Assessment for Learning (AfL) principles (Black & Wiliam, 1998). WT provides a lens to understand how assessment practices, specifically the use of analytic rubrics, influence teaching and learning behaviors within the classroom. It emphasizes that the effects of assessment are neither uniform nor automatic but mediated by various factors, including teachers' beliefs, institutional policies, and student expectations. AfL, by contrast, centers on the idea that assessment is most effective when it informs and enhances learning during the instructional process. Core principles of AfL include clarifying learning intentions, sharing success criteria, providing actionable feedback, encouraging peer and self-assessment, and promoting learner autonomy. In this study, AfL provides a complementary framework to WT by emphasizing the formative potential of assessment tools like analytic rubrics when integrated into day-to-day instruction. AfL principles highlight the formative potential of analytic rubrics when used to clarify expectations, promote self-regulation, and better meaningful feedback dialogues between teachers and students.

Together, these frameworks help examine both the expected and unexpected effects of using rubrics. They also support a dynamic view of lecturers as active agents who interpret and adapt assessment tools based on their professional knowledge, pedagogical goals, and contextual constraints. Importantly, the intersection between WT and AfL in this study allows for the exploration of not only how rubrics affect teaching behaviors (washback) but also how they can be leveraged as vehicles for formative assessment to improve student learning outcomes. By grounding the study in these theoretical frameworks, the research aims to show how analytic rubrics are used not only for scoring but also for shaping teaching practices in EFL writing instruction.

Besides, the analytic rubrics used in this study were developed by the research team as part of a previous project aimed at standardizing writing assessment in Vietnamese EFL contexts. The development process included iterative consultations with local EFL experts, alignment with CEFR writing descriptors, and multiple rounds of piloting in actual classroom settings. The final rubrics were peer-reviewed and published in a well-known journal in the field, ensuring their theoretical soundness and practical relevance. The rubrics include five components: content (30 points), organization (20 points), vocabulary (20 points), language use (25 points), and mechanics (5 points). Prior to this study, participating lecturers received training on how to interpret and apply the rubrics consistently across writing tasks. However, how these rubrics were subsequently used, adapted, and integrated into their ongoing teaching and assessment practices became the central concern of the present study.

Participants

The participants in this study were nine Vietnamese EFL lecturers teaching at two higher education institutions in Vietnam. To capture a range of perspectives across different career stages, the sample was purposefully selected to include three novice lecturers (with fewer than 5 years of teaching experience), three mid-career lecturers (with between 5 and 15 years of experience), and three near-end-career lecturers (with more than 15 years of experience). This distribution allowed for an exploration of how teaching experience and professional development might mediate the washback effects of rubric use.

To protect their identities and ensure confidentiality, all participants were assigned pseudonyms. The novice lecturers were given the names Minh, Hanh, and Tuan; the mid-career lecturers were named Lan, Hong, and Quan; and the near-end-career lecturers were referred to as Hoa, Dung, and Vinh. Table 1 presents a summary of the participants' demographic information.

Participants were recruited through professional networks and direct invitations, with voluntary participation emphasized throughout the recruitment process. Prior to data collection, all participants were provided with detailed information about the purpose of the study, the nature of their involvement, and their rights as research participants. Informed consent was obtained in writing, and participants were reminded that they could withdraw from the study at any point without consequence. Additionally, all participants had been introduced to the research team's analytic rubrics through institutional workshops or department-led assessment initiatives. While the rubrics themselves were standardized, lecturers retained some autonomy in how they applied them,

Table 1 Participants

No.	Pseudonyms	Gender	Experience
1	Minh	Male	Novice
2	Hanh	Female	Novice
3	Tuan	Male	Novice
4	Lan	Female	Mid-career
5	Hong	Female	Mid-career
6	Quan	Male	Mid-career
7	Hoa	Female	Near-end-career
8	Dung	Male	Near-end-career
9	Vinh	Male	Near-end-career

either for summative grading or as part of formative instruction. This variation in how participants used rubrics helped show how rubric design connects with local teaching practices.

Ethical considerations were central to the design and implementation of the study. The research protocol was reviewed and approved by the ethics committees of both participating institutions. All interview data were anonymized, and identifying information was removed during transcription and analysis. Data were stored securely, with access restricted to the primary researcher. Throughout the study, efforts were made to respect participants' autonomy, ensure their comfort during interviews, and represent their voices accurately and respectfully in the reporting of findings.

Data collection

Data for this study were collected through semi-structured interviews designed to explore EFL lecturers' experiences and perceptions regarding the use of analytic rubrics in writing assessment. To ensure the effectiveness and clarity of the interview protocol, a pilot study was conducted with two lecturers who shared similar backgrounds to the main participants but were not part of the final sample. Feedback from the pilot study revealed that some questions were overly broad and occasionally led participants away from the core research focus. Based on this feedback, revisions were made to the interview guide, including refining question wording for greater clarity and adjusting the sequence of questions to encourage a more natural conversational flow.

The final interview guide contained questions aimed at eliciting detailed narratives about participants' practices, beliefs, and experiences. Examples of revised questions included: "Can you describe how you typically use the analytic rubric when assessing students' writing?", "In what ways has the rubric influenced the way you design writing lessons?", "Have you noticed any changes in your students' writing or learning behaviors as a result of using the rubric?", and "What challenges have you faced when using analytic rubrics, and how have you addressed them?" These open-ended questions encouraged participants to describe their experiences and reflections, helping the researchers better understand the effects of rubric use.

Each participant was interviewed individually, with interviews lasting between 45 and 60 min. To accommodate participants' schedules and ensure a comfortable environment, interviews were conducted either in participants' offices or in quiet meeting

rooms on campus. In some cases where in-person interviews were not feasible, interviews were conducted via secure online platforms with participants' consent. All interviews were conducted in Vietnamese, the participants' native language, to facilitate ease of expression and to capture the subtleties of their experiences more authentically. Using Vietnamese helped minimize misunderstandings and made it easier for participants to explain educational and cultural ideas more clearly.

All interviews were audio-recorded with participants' permission and later transcribed verbatim for analysis. Transcriptions were carefully reviewed alongside the recordings to ensure accuracy. Throughout the data collection process, the researcher maintained a flexible and empathetic interviewing stance, allowing participants to elaborate freely and pursue relevant topics beyond the prepared guide when appropriate. Field notes were also taken during and immediately after interviews to record first impressions, emotional reactions, and contextual details that could support later interpretation of the data.

Data analysis

The data collected from the semi-structured interviews were analyzed using thematic analysis, following the procedures outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006). Thematic analysis was chosen for its flexibility and its ability to identify, analyze, and report patterns within qualitative data. The process began with a familiarization phase, where the researchers read and re-read the interview transcripts in both Vietnamese and English to become thoroughly familiar with the content. During this stage, preliminary notes and reflections were recorded to capture early impressions and emerging ideas.

Following familiarization, the researcher systematically generated initial codes across the dataset. Coding was conducted manually, with careful attention paid to capturing both semantic (explicit) and latent (underlying) meanings in the participants' accounts. To determine coding segments, the research team followed a meaning-based segmentation protocol, identifying segments as discrete units of thought in which participants expressed a specific idea, experience, or reflection relevant to the research question. These segments typically ranged from a sentence to a short paragraph and were bounded by shifts in topic, perspective, or narrative focus. This approach aligns with Braun and Clarke's (2006) recommendation to define segments based on interpretive relevance rather than fixed length. Each segment of text relevant to the research question was labeled with a concise code that represented a significant feature of the data. Codes were then grouped into broader categories that reflected recurring patterns or issues related to rubric use, teaching practices, lecturer beliefs, student responses, and perceived challenges.

For transparency and auditability, Table 2 presents a sample of the initial codes and illustrates how these were clustered into broader categories and eventually developed into overarching themes.

After generating the initial codes, the researcher moved to the stage of searching for themes by collating related codes into potential thematic clusters. These clusters were continually reviewed and refined to ensure that they accurately represented the underlying data and were distinct yet interconnected. Themes were then clearly

Table 2 A sample of the initial codes

	Sample codes	Category	Theme
1	Used rubric only after grading	Timing for rubrics use	Summative vs. formative use of rubrics
2	Students write to meet each criterion	Student engagement with rubrics	Instrumental vs. deep engagement
3	Rubrics helped organize lessons	Instructional adaptation	Rubrics as pedagogical tools
4	Rubrics too complex for weak students	Student challenges	Rubrics accessibility and equity
5	Taught rubrics explicitly before writing	Formative integration	Rubrics in formative assessment practices
6	...	...	...

Table 3 Thematic analysis of lecturer data on the washback of analytic rubrics

	Themes	Definitions	Coded examples
1	Summative vs. formative use of rubrics	Extent to which rubrics were used as post-hoc scoring tools or formative instructional guides.	"I mostly look at the rubric after I finish reading the essay." (Minh)
2	Selective emphasis on rubric	Tendency to focus on language and organization while neglecting other criteria like content or creativity.	"I tend to focus first on grammar mistakes... creativity, I do not emphasize." (Tuan)
3	Adaptation of rubrics to context	Modification or simplification of rubrics to suit classroom needs or student levels.	"I simplify it into three main focuses: ideas, language, and structure." (Vinh)
...	...	...	...

defined and named, ensuring that each theme captured a specific aspect of the participants' experiences regarding the washback of analytic rubrics.

Table 3 displays the thematic analysis results, presenting the names, definitions, and representative examples of each theme related to the washback of analytic rubrics.

Throughout this process, the researcher remained mindful of maintaining the participants' intended meanings, especially given the cross-language context, by cross-checking the original Vietnamese transcripts with their English translations where necessary.

To enhance the credibility and trustworthiness of the analysis, a second coder, who was fluent in Vietnamese and experienced in qualitative research, independently reviewed three randomly selected transcripts from the nine interviews. A total of 18 initial codes were compared, with four minor discrepancies identified concerning the interpretation of latent meanings. Discrepancies were discussed and resolved through negotiation. Additionally, thick descriptions and direct quotations from participants were used in the reporting of findings to ground the interpretations firmly in the data and to allow readers to engage directly with the participants' voices. To further validate the accuracy of the findings, a member checking process was conducted with six of the nine participants. These lecturers were invited to review a summary of the themes and key interpretations and were asked whether the analysis accurately reflected their perspectives and experiences. Their feedback confirmed the relevance and resonance of the findings.

Researcher positionally statements

As a research team, we are Vietnamese EFL lecturers, each with at least 4 years of experience teaching English in higher education institutions. Our collective background in language instruction, writing pedagogy, and teacher education informed our understanding of the participants' contexts and the subtleties of rubric use in tertiary classrooms. This professional proximity enabled us to interpret participant narratives with contextual sensitivity. At the same time, we were mindful of the potential influence of our own assumptions. To mitigate bias, we engaged in regular team discussions, maintained reflective journals during the analysis process, and cross-validated our interpretations through peer debriefing and collaborative coding reviews. These practices supported transparency and helped ensure that our findings were grounded in the participants' voices rather than filtered through our own professional perspectives.

Findings

How lecturers implement rubrics

Analysis of the interview data revealed several patterns regarding how EFL lecturers implemented analytic rubrics in their writing assessment practices. Participants' approaches varied depending on their career stages, with notable differences in how thoroughly rubrics were integrated into instructional and evaluative routines. Across the nine participants, five (two novice teachers, two mid-career teachers, and one near-end-career teacher) reported using rubrics primarily as scoring tools after assignments were submitted, while four (one novice, one mid-career, and two near-end-career teachers) described more integrated uses of rubrics throughout the instructional process.

One major finding was that several lecturers, particularly novice and mid-career teachers, treated the rubric mainly as an assessment checklist to justify scores rather than as a tool to guide student learning. For instance, Minh, a novice lecturer, explained: "I mostly look at the rubric after I finish reading the essay. Then, I assign the points according to the boxes that fit best. I do not really show the rubric to students before they write." This practice reflects a form of product-oriented washback, where the assessment influences students only at the point of evaluation rather than during learning. From an AfL perspective, Minh's approach missed the formative potential of rubrics, as the criteria were not used to scaffold learning during the writing process but merely to assign scores retrospectively.

In contrast, some lecturers, particularly those nearing the end of their careers, described more formative uses of rubrics. Hoa, a near-end-career lecturer, shared: "Before each writing assignment, I spend time going through the rubric with the students. We discuss what each part means and what good writing should look like according to the rubric. I also ask them to use it to check their drafts before submitting." Hoa's implementation reflects positive washback, where assessment tools actively shape instruction and learning behaviors in a constructive way. Through the lens of AfL, Hoa's practice exemplifies using assessment as an integral part of instruction, promoting clarity, student self-regulation, and a shared understanding of quality writing.

Another theme that emerged was selective emphasis on certain rubric components. Six lecturers (three novices, two mid-career, and one near-end) reported focusing more

heavily on language accuracy and organization when applying the rubric, while often paying less attention to content development or critical thinking aspects. Tuan, a novice lecturer, commented: "Even though the rubric has many parts, I tend to focus first on grammar mistakes and then how logical the ideas are. Other parts like creativity, I do not emphasize much because it is harder to grade." This selective focus suggests a narrowing effect, where only the most easily measurable components drive teaching and evaluation—a form of negative washback. From an AfL perspective, this practice risks distorting students' understanding of writing quality by overemphasizing technical correctness at the expense of deeper engagement with ideas.

Moreover, participants varied in how consistently they applied the rubric criteria. Three lecturers (one novice, one mid-career, one near-end) admitted that while rubrics provided a framework, final scores often reflected their "overall impression" of the student's work. Hong, a mid-career lecturer, reflected: "Sometimes, even if a student's essay ticks all the rubric points, it still feels weak. So I adjust the score a little based on my gut feeling." This inconsistency indicates the influence of lecturers' personal judgment and experience, which WT acknowledges as a mediator between assessment tools and actual practice. From the standpoint of AfL, such practices undermine the transparency and fairness intended by rubric-based assessment, potentially confusing students about what is expected and how to improve.

Finally, some lecturers adapted rubrics informally to fit specific course needs. Vinh, a near-end-career lecturer, described: "The official rubric is quite detailed, but in my class, I simplify it into three main focuses: ideas, language, and structure. It is easier for students to remember and for me to teach." While this adaptation reflects a flexible, context-sensitive approach aligning with AfL principles of making assessment meaningful and accessible, it also raises concerns from a washback perspective about how modification might alter the intended balance of assessed skills and lead to inconsistent interpretations of writing quality.

These findings show that EFL lecturers use analytic rubrics in a range of different ways. Their practices reflect a continuum of washback effects, shaped by career stage, beliefs about writing, perceptions of assessment purposes, and instructional contexts. While some lecturers successfully integrated rubrics to promote learning and clarity, others used them more narrowly as scoring tools, limiting their formative potential.

How lecturers' perceptions evolve

The analysis also revealed that lecturers' perceptions of analytic rubrics evolved over time, influenced by their teaching experiences, interactions with students, and reflections on assessment challenges. All nine participants, regardless of career stage, indicated that their understanding and attitudes toward rubric use had changed since they first began employing them. However, the nature and direction of these changes varied according to their teaching experience and professional growth.

Among the novice lecturers, initial perceptions of rubrics were largely shaped by institutional requirements rather than personal conviction. Minh, for example, noted: "At first, I thought rubrics were just a formal thing we had to use for reporting grades. I did not really see how they could help with teaching." This perspective reflects the concept in WT that external pressures often drive initial assessment behaviors, with

limited internalization of the tool's pedagogical value. From an AfL perspective, Minh's early view highlights a missed opportunity to use rubrics formatively, viewing them primarily as administrative artifacts rather than instructional supports.

However, with more teaching experience, novice lecturers began to recognize the pedagogical benefits of rubric use. Hanh, another novice, shared: "After a few semesters, I realized that when I explained the rubric clearly before students wrote, their essays improved. They understood better what was expected." This evolution suggests a movement toward positive washback, as the lecturer shifted from using rubrics solely for grading to using them as tools for clarifying learning objectives and supporting student growth. From the AfL perspective, this shift shows stronger involvement in using assessment to support learning rather than just to measure it.

Mid-career lecturers showed a more gradual shift in how they viewed rubrics. At first, they saw rubrics as useful but inflexible tools; over time, they came to see how rubrics could be adjusted to better match different student needs and teaching goals. Lan, a mid-career lecturer, explained: "At first, I followed the rubric strictly, almost mechanically. But over time, I learned to use it as a guide, not a rulebook. I focus on the spirit of each category, not just ticking boxes." Lan's shift reflects an increasingly sophisticated view of assessment: adaptive washback, where teachers interpret assessment frameworks flexibly to serve meaningful learning purposes. In AfL terms, this change reflects a shift from using assessment criteria as fixed rules to using them as tools for discussion and helping students assess their own work.

For near-end-career lecturers, their long-term experience led to even more reflective and strategic perceptions of rubric use. Hoa, for instance, described her current view: "Now, I see the rubric as a conversation starter. It is not just me evaluating them. It is me and the students working together to understand what good writing looks like." This relational approach resonates strongly with both WT's ideal of positive, learning-enhancing effects and the AfL emphasis on assessment as an interactive, formative process. Hoa's perspective suggests that experienced lecturers are more likely to integrate rubrics into broader pedagogical dialogues that empower students to take ownership of their learning.

Nonetheless, some near-end-career lecturers also expressed tensions between their evolving beliefs and institutional constraints. Dung reflected: "Even though I want to use the rubric flexibly, sometimes I have to stick to it strictly because of department regulations. Otherwise, my grading is questioned." This tension highlights how both individual choices and institutional rules shape whether formative assessment practices can be fully applied, as emphasized in WT.

Overall, the findings indicate that lecturers' perceptions of analytic rubrics shifted over time, evolving from seeing them primarily as external administrative requirements to recognizing their value as tools for supporting and enhancing instruction. This evolution was mediated by accumulated teaching experience, reflective practice, and negotiation with institutional expectations. From both theoretical perspectives, lecturers' growing appreciation for the formative potential of rubrics marks a shift toward more positive washback and more meaningful implementation of AfL principles in EFL writing classrooms.

How rubric use influences students' learning experiences

The final major theme that emerged from the data concerned how lecturers perceived the influence of analytic rubrics on their students' learning experiences and writing development. All nine participants observed that rubric use had notable effects on students' engagement with writing tasks, although the nature and extent of these effects varied according to how rubrics were implemented in instruction.

Several lecturers (two novices, two mid-career, and two near-end-career teachers) reported that when rubrics were shared with students before writing tasks, students demonstrated greater clarity about expectations and improved self-monitoring abilities. Lan, a mid-career lecturer, explained: "When students have the rubric from the beginning, they know exactly what to aim for. They are more focused and make fewer basic mistakes." This perception aligns with positive washback, where assessment tools actively influence learning behaviors by providing clear goals. From an AfL perspective, Lan's observation highlights the crucial role of transparency and goal-setting in promoting student ownership and strategic engagement in the writing process.

Similarly, Hoa, a near-end-career lecturer, observed improvements in her students' ability to self-assess and revise their drafts: "I ask students to use the rubric to check their own work before submitting. Many of them became more independent and critical about their writing." This practice shows how rubrics can be used formatively to build students' awareness of their own thinking and learning, which is a key idea in AfL. It also exemplifies the positive washback that occurs when assessment tools are integrated into ongoing learning activities rather than used only for final judgment.

However, the findings also reveal some unintended negative effects when rubrics were not well integrated into instruction. Four participants (two novices, one mid-career, and one near-end-career) noted that some students treated the rubric mechanically, aiming only to fulfill checklist items without engaging deeply with the writing task. Tuan, a novice lecturer, explained*: "Some students just try to match the rubric points without thinking much about their ideas. They write very formulaically."* This phenomenon exemplifies what to be referred to as instrumental washback, where the presence of assessment criteria leads to surface-level learning strategies. From the AfL lens, it highlights the risk of turning writing instruction into a box-ticking exercise instead of encouraging real communication and thoughtful ideas.

Another critical point raised by several lecturers was that rubric complexity sometimes overwhelmed students, particularly lower-proficiency writers. Dung, a near-end-career lecturer, commented: "The rubric has too many categories. Some weaker students do not know where to start. They feel lost and frustrated." Such experiences indicate that without careful scaffolding, rubrics intended to support learning may inadvertently discourage or confuse students, resulting in negative washback. In terms of AfL, this underscores the importance of aligning assessment practices with students' developmental readiness and providing adequate support for interpreting and using rubrics effectively.

Interestingly, two lecturers, Quan (mid-career) and Vinh (near-end-career), suggested that culturally embedded views of education also influenced students' reactions to rubrics. Quan remarked: "Vietnamese students are used to following teacher instructions very closely. So they see the rubric as another set of rules to memorize, not something flexible or negotiable." This observation resonates with WT's emphasis on

contextual mediators and reflects the need for culturally responsive assessment practices that consider students' expectations and learning habits. From an AfL standpoint, it points to the challenge of fostering active student participation in assessment dialogues in contexts where hierarchical educational traditions prevail.

In summary, the use of analytic rubrics had both positive and negative influences on students' learning experiences. When effectively introduced and integrated, rubrics helped clarify expectations, support self-regulation, and enhance writing development, demonstrating positive washback and alignment with AfL principles. However, when rubrics were treated rigidly or were insufficiently explained, they sometimes led to superficial engagement, confusion, or formulaic writing behaviors.

Discussion

This study set out to explore the washback effects of EFL lecturers' use of analytic rubrics on their assessment practices, instructional approaches, and students' writing development in Vietnamese higher education contexts. The findings generally align with previous research on the value of rubrics for teaching and learning, while also revealing specific patterns that add to what is known about how rubrics influence instruction and assessment.

Regarding how lecturers implement rubrics, the current findings are partly consistent with earlier studies such as those by Cheng and Warren (2005) and Fraile et al. (2017), which found that while rubrics offer clarity and structure, teachers often implement them in diverse and sometimes inconsistent ways. Similar to Fraile et al.'s (2017) observations of Spanish university lecturers adapting rubrics informally, this study found that Vietnamese lecturers sometimes selectively emphasized rubric components or relied on personal impressions despite having structured criteria. However, a distinctive contribution of this study lies in its identification of patterns across career stages: novice lecturers were more likely to use rubrics rigidly or as post-hoc scoring tools, whereas near-end-career lecturers often integrated rubrics more dialogically into instruction. This career-stage differentiation adds to existing research by indicating that teaching experience may influence both how consistently rubrics are applied and the extent to which they are used formatively. This finding supports the developmental trajectory proposed by Andrade et al. (2008) but extends it by illustrating how career stage mediates both assessment behavior and openness to formative principles, offering empirical support for Panadero and Jonsson's (2013) argument that training and experience are essential for effective rubric implementation.

In terms of lecturers' evolving perceptions of rubrics, the study aligns with Andrade et al.'s (2008) conclusion that experience with rubrics can lead to greater appreciation of their instructional value. Like their findings, the lecturers in this study initially viewed rubrics as bureaucratic necessities but gradually came to recognize their role in supporting student learning. However, a key difference in this study is the attention to institutional constraints that sometimes counteract lecturers' positive evolution. While Andrade et al. (2008) emphasized the natural developmental trajectory of rubric use with experience, the present study highlights the tensions experienced by Vietnamese lecturers who, even after internalizing AfL principles, sometimes had to revert to rigid rubric application to satisfy administrative auditing or departmental

demands. This illustrates Green's (2007a, 2007b) and Shih's (2009) assertion that washback is shaped by the interaction between institutional mandates and teacher agency, and it reinforces Carless and Winstone's (2019) position that sustainable formative assessment practices require both pedagogical commitment and systemic support. Thus, the study contributes to WT by empirically demonstrating that positive washback is not an inherent feature of formative tools like rubrics but a dynamic outcome shaped by institutional affordances and constraints.

Concerning how rubric use influences students' learning experiences, the findings both confirm and extend prior research. Consistent with Cheng and Warren's (2005) and Saito's (2008) observations, when rubrics were introduced transparently, students reportedly showed better understanding of writing expectations and greater self-monitoring abilities. However, this study also revealed that if rubric instruction was superficial or too mechanical, students tended to engage in formulaic writing, focusing narrowly on ticking off rubric categories rather than developing coherent and original arguments. While prior studies like Hamp-Lyons (2007) acknowledged the risk of formulaic writing under rubric-driven assessments, this study provides more detailed, culturally specific evidence: Vietnamese students' culturally ingrained tendencies toward rule-following appeared to intensify this instrumental engagement with rubrics. Furthermore, the study found that lower-proficiency students often struggled with the rubric's detailed structure, an issue that earlier research has not clearly discussed. These insights reinforce Xu and Brown's (2016) claim that student assessment literacy and cultural dispositions mediate how formative assessment tools are internalized and acted upon. Moreover, they highlight the need for pedagogical scaffolding that supports students' interpretation of rubrics as learning tools rather than compliance checklists, echoing Joseph et al.'s (2020) argument for dialogic rubric practices.

Moreover, this study's integration of both WT and AfL perspectives offers a more layered interpretation of the data than many previous rubric washback studies. While prior research often framed washback either as positive/negative outcomes (e.g., Green, 2007a, 2007b) or emphasized rubric clarity as the main success factor (e.g., Andrade et al., 2008), the present study shows that the mere presence of an analytic rubric is not enough. Instead, positive learning effects depend on how rubrics are socially negotiated within classroom interactions, how they are embedded in wider assessment ecologies, and how lecturers' professional identities and institutional realities shape their enactment. This supports Carless and Winstone's (2019) focus on lasting feedback practices and aligns with Panadero et al.'s (2018) view that rubrics can help students manage their own learning more effectively. The study thus bridges WT and AfL by showing how rubrics can serve as both vehicles of institutional accountability and tools for pedagogical dialogue, depending on how they are operationalized.

In sum, while this study confirms much of what previous research has identified about the potential and challenges of rubric-based assessment, it also introduces new dimensions related to career-stage differences, institutional tensions, cultural influences on students' rubric engagement, and the complex mediation of formative assessment ideals by real-world constraints. By situating these findings within the

dual lenses of WT and AfL, the study contributes a theoretically grounded, empirically informed account of how formative assessment tools like analytic rubrics function within localized pedagogical ecologies.

Conclusion

This study explored how analytic rubrics shape teaching, learning, and assessment in Vietnamese EFL writing classrooms. By examining the washback effects of rubric use across a range of lecturer career stages, the findings highlight variation in implementation, from summative, compliance-oriented approaches to more formative, dialogic uses. These practices were influenced not only by teaching experience but also by institutional constraints and student-related challenges. Drawing on WT and AfL principles, the study helps explain how rubrics are used as teaching tools within particular sociocultural settings.

These findings give rise to several important implications for educational practice. First, professional development programs for EFL lecturers should not only introduce analytic rubrics but also provide ongoing training in their formative use, helping teachers see rubrics as teaching tools rather than merely evaluation instruments. Special attention should be given to novice teachers, supporting their transition from rigid to more reflective and dialogic uses of rubrics. Second, institutions should recognize that rigid enforcement of rubric compliance may counteract positive washback; greater flexibility and trust in lecturers' professional judgment are needed to fully realize the formative potential of rubrics. Third, when designing rubrics for EFL contexts, attention must be paid to the cognitive load they impose on students, ensuring that rubrics are accessible and comprehensible to learners of varying proficiency levels.

Limitations and recommendations for further studies

While this study provides valuable insights into the washback effects of analytic rubric use among Vietnamese EFL lecturers, several limitations must be acknowledged. First, although generalizability was not the goal of this qualitative study, the sample size, nine participants from two institutions, may limit the transferability of the findings to other EFL settings. While the design prioritized depth over breadth, the findings may not capture the full range of rubric-related practices and beliefs across all EFL teaching contexts. Moreover, the study relied exclusively on self-reported data collected through one-time, semi-structured interviews. While these interviews offered detailed personal accounts, they were not supported by other data sources like classroom observations, rubric samples, or student feedback. This reliance on retrospective accounts may limit the ability to fully capture how lecturers' assessment behaviors evolved over time or how rubrics were enacted in actual classroom settings. The absence of observational or longitudinal data presents a methodological gap, particularly for a study concerned with evolving assessment practices.

To build upon the findings of this study, future research should consider larger, more diverse samples across different types of educational institutions, including private universities and rural colleges, to capture a broader range of experiences with rubric use. Equally important, future research should incorporate multiple sources of data, such as classroom observations, student writing samples, rubric annotations, and student

interviews or focus groups, to triangulate findings and better document how rubrics are actually implemented and experienced in practice. Longitudinal research following lecturers over several semesters could also shed light on how perceptions and practices evolve over time in response to institutional changes and professional development initiatives. Furthermore, studies comparing how rubrics are used in different cultural settings could show how local teaching traditions affect their impact and help improve rubric design for use in a variety of EFL classrooms.

Abbreviations

AfL Assessment for Learning
EFL English as a Foreign Language
WT Washback Theory

Author contributions

Phuong supervised the study. Phuong and Le were responsible for data collection. Le and Pham conducted the data analysis and drafted the main manuscript. All authors reviewed and approved the final manuscript.

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Data Availability

No datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

Declarations

Ethics approval and consent to participate

This study was conducted with a strong commitment to upholding ethical standards in research. As experienced researchers in the field of social studies, we carefully adhered to all relevant ethical guidelines and found no violations. In addition, we obtained oral consent from all participants prior to their involvement.

Consent for publication

Not applicable.

Competing interests

The authors declare no competing interests.

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